Dr Tristan Hotham

Researcher on social media, campaigns and politics

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PROFILE

I study how political parties, leaders and campaigns use social media, and how audiences respond. My ESRC-funded PhD at the University of Bath analysed how British parties used Facebook from 2010 to 2018 and introduced the idea of Janus-faced campaigning. I combine digital trace data, hand coding and text-as-data methods, and publish open access with aggregate data. Since 2021 I have worked in the civil service on the regulation of digital markets and cyber resilience; my research is independent of that role.

EXPERIENCE

Civil servant, policy 2021 to present

- Cyber resilience: work on the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill (2025 to present).
- Digital markets: policy adviser working on the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act (2021 to 2025).

Research consultant, Who Targets Me 2019

- Analysed targeted political advertising during the 2019 General Election using ad data crowdsourced from volunteers; findings were widely reported in the press.

Independent researcher 2026 to present

- Twenty-one open-access preprints on Facebook, campaigns and elections in Britain, Europe and the United States (2026), each with a DOI and, where the terms of collection allow, aggregate data.

EDUCATION

PhD, Politics, University of Bath (ESRC funded) 2016 to 2021

Thesis: *How do political parties use Facebook and what does it offer to their campaigns*. Awarded April 2021. 49,551 extracted posts and 1,481 hand-coded posts.

MRes, University of Bath · **MA, Politics**, Durham University · **LLB**, University of Exeter

SELECTED RESEARCH

- Hotham, T. (2026). *Do Populists Win on Facebook? The Engagement Premium of Populist Parties in Europe, 2010 to 2020*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23270349
- Hotham, T. (2026). *Same Message, Thousands of Times: Targeted Facebook Advertising by British Parties at the 2017 and 2019 General Elections*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23264728
- Hotham, T. (2026). *What Does a Satellite Campaign Do? Momentum, the Labour Party and Jeremy Corbyn on Facebook in the 2017 General Election*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23296711
- Hotham, T. (2026). *Who Carries the Party on Facebook? Leaders, Party Pages and the Polls in Britain, 2010 to 2020*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23263763
- Hotham, T. (2026). *Who Won the Facebook Referendum? Engagement, Tone and Nationalism on UK Party and Campaign Pages, February to June 2016*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23260111
- Hotham, T. (2026). *Not a Forecast: The Radical Right on Facebook in Sweden, Norway and Denmark, 2014 to 2020*. Preprint. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23302596
- Hotham, T. (2021). *How do political parties use Facebook and what does it offer to their campaigns*. PhD thesis, University of Bath. doi:10.5281/zenodo.23300280
- Hotham, T. (2019). "Behind the curtain of the targeting machine": political parties A/B testing in action. In *UK Election Analysis 2019*.

Full list of 22 papers with abstracts: tristanhotham.com/research. Preprints are not peer reviewed.

CONFERENCE PAPERS

- Labour's 2017 General Election campaign: what sets Momentum apart from the leader and party page? PSA Annual Conference (online), 2021.
- Permanent satellite campaigning? Momentum across the 2017 General Election and 2018 permanent campaign. PSA Annual Conference (online), 2021.
- Is it party leader pages or party pages that matter most on UK Facebook? PSA Annual Conference, Nottingham, 2019.
- Researching Facebook in troubled times. SWDTP Conference, Bristol, 2018.
- Facebook and Big Data: has it changed party campaigning in Britain forever? (with D. Cutts). EPOP Conference, Canterbury, 2016.

COMMENTARY AND EVIDENCE

- Written evidence to the House of Lords Democracy and Digital Technologies Committee (DAD0021).
- Trump v Biden: who is engaging the most followers on Facebook? *The Conversation*, 2020.
- Brexit and election advertising: an asset for some, a liability for others. *Democratic Audit / LSE*, 2020.
- We need to talk about A/B testing: Brexit, attack ads and the election campaign. *LSE Brexit Blog*, 2019.
- The digital campaign: targeted advertising in the 2019 General Election. *PSA News Blog*, 2019.
- Facebook risks starting a war on knowledge. *The Conversation*, 2018.

MEDIA

Research reported or discussed by The Observer, The Economist, The New York Times, the Financial Times, Reuters, The Telegraph, The Independent, Wired, New Scientist, Bloomberg Opinion and the Evening Standard. Broadcast commentary for BBC World News, BBC World Service, Sky News, ITV News, BBC local radio, LBC and Channel 5 News (2019 to 2020).

METHODS

Digital trace data (CrowdTangle, Netvizz, Facebook Ad Library); content analysis and hand coding with reliability testing; text as data; regression and panel models; survey data.

Views are my own. Descriptions of civil service work draw only on published material. Updated October 2026.